

Seminar 9 — Climate Policy Cases

IR227 Politics of Change

July 2026

What you'll do in 90 minutes

[Bridge to seminar] *Take your assigned climate-policy case. Apply the seven-condition checklist (Lecture 7) jointly with the institutional-change mechanisms typology (Lecture 8). Reach an effectiveness verdict. Then close with a coalition-or-institutional reflection: what specific move could improve the case's trajectory?*

- Six cases, three pairs, deliberately paired.
- Each group: 3–4 students, one case.
- Joint diagnosis, then draft a briefing, exchange with your paired group, and present.

Three methodological points up front

1. Climate is a distributional-conflict problem, not a collective-action problem; free-riding is not the binding constraint. (Aklin and Mildemberger 2020)
2. Industry is a variable, not just an opponent — Lecture 7's point recurs; identify which firms in your case are pro-regulation.
3. Commitment problems are the recurring binding constraint — Lecture 5's framework recurs; the credibility of policy and just-transition support shapes effectiveness.

Six cases, three pairs

Pair archetype	Case A	Case B
Mitigation policy effectiveness	EU CBAM	China national ETS
Adaptation justice + loss/damage	Pacific small-island states	Bangladesh
Just transition	Germany coal phase-out	South Africa JETP

Within each pair: same archetype, different conditions, different commitment infrastructure. (Aklin and Mildenberger 2020; Stechemesser et al. 2024; United Nations Environment Programme 2024)

Recap: the conditions checklist

Framework: Conditions for environmental-governance success (Lecture 7)

1. Scientific consensus + epistemic community.
2. Concentrated industry / actors.
3. Available technological substitutes.
4. Asymmetric costs favouring cooperation.
5. Distributional mechanisms.
6. Institutional design (monitoring, verification, enforcement).
7. Political leadership.

Recap: institutional-change mechanisms

Drift. Rules unchanged, environment changes.

Conversion. Rules redirected to new purposes.

Layering. New rules added on top of old without dismantling.

Displacement. Old institutions actively replaced by new.

Exhaustion. Institutions wither without intentional replacement.

Which mechanism is operative in your case — and what's the prior rule it's building on or replacing?

Recap: distributional conflict, not collective action

- Aklin and Mildemberger's empirical critique: governments implement climate policies regardless of what other countries do; free-riding is not the binding constraint. (Aklin and Mildemberger 2020)
- Four dimensions of within-country distributional conflict: industry vs. industry; concentrated losers vs. diffuse winners; high-income vs. low-income households (regressive incidence); current voters vs. future generations.
- Colgan, Green, and Hale: asset revaluation distinguishes CFAs (climate-forcing assets) from CVAs (climate-vulnerable assets); both lose value as decarbonisation proceeds. (Colgan et al. 2021)

Which dimension is binding in your case — and which assets are being revalued?

Phase 1 — joint diagnosis (20 min, no laptops)

1. For each of the seven conditions, identify present, partial, or absent, with evidence.
2. Identify which mechanism (drift, conversion, layering, displacement, exhaustion) is most operative, with evidence.
3. Show how the conditions and the mechanism connect, and reach an effectiveness verdict.

Output: a conditions assessment + mechanism identification + effectiveness verdict — something you can defend and will report to the class.

Phase 2 — draft your briefing (15 min, Claude allowed)

Case: Diagnostic memo

- One paragraph: diagnosis-and-verdict memo — conditions, mechanism, binding constraint, verdict.
- Two-to-three sentences: coalition-or-institutional reflection — what specific move could improve the case's trajectory?

Be specific. Name the industry, the workers, the institutional design.

Phase 3 — exchange briefings (5 min)

- Swap your written briefing with your comparative-case group (same archetype, paired case).
- Read their verdict, evidence, and coalition-or-institutional reflection.
- Note one point of contrast to raise in the plenary: same archetype — why does the verdict differ?

Phase 4 — present (5 min per group)

Each group presents its own diagnosis and verdict, then names the contrast with its comparative case.

- Mitigation effectiveness: EU CBAM vs. China ETS — same instrument-type, different scale and political economy. Why?
- Adaptation justice: Pacific small-island states vs. Bangladesh — different vulnerability profiles, different governance strategies. Why?
- Just transition: Germany vs. South Africa — domestic vs. international commitment infrastructure. Why?

Three things to take away

1. Climate is the test case for the analytical toolkit. Conditions checklist and mechanisms typology jointly diagnose.
2. Distributional conflict, not collective action, is the binding constraint.
Within-country political economy dominates. (Aklin and Mildenberger 2020)
3. Coalition-building and commitment-problem design are the strategic responses.
Conditions can be built. (Meckling et al. 2015)

Monday: demographic and migration governance — where welfare-state material returns and climate-driven displacement enters.

- Aklin, M. and M. Mildemberger (Nov. 2020). **“Prisoners of the Wrong Dilemma: Why Distributive Conflict, Not Collective Action, Characterizes the Politics of Climate Change”**. In: *Global Environmental Politics* 20.4, pp. 4–27.
- Colgan, J. D., J. F. Green, and T. N. Hale (2021). **“Asset Revaluation and the Existential Politics of Climate Change”**. In: *International Organization* 75.2, pp. 586–610.
- Meckling, J., N. Kelsey, E. Biber, and J. Zysman (2015). **“Winning coalitions for climate policy”**. In: *Science* 349.6253, pp. 1170–1171.
- Stechemesser, A. et al. (2024). **“Climate policies that achieved major emission reductions: Global evidence from two decades”**. In: *Science* 385.6711, pp. 884–892.

United Nations Environment Programme (2024). **Emissions Gap Report 2024: No More Hot Air ... Please! With a Massive Gap Between Rhetoric and Reality, Countries Draft New Climate Commitments.** Tech. rep. Nairobi: United Nations Environment Programme.